Bread Proofer

Category: **Food Processing & Kitchen** Type: **Full SOP** Priority: **High** 1 labs

Covers these lab items: Bread Proofer (Optional)

What it is used for

A bread proofer provides controlled warmth and humidity to help yeast dough rise before baking. Use the correct settings and proofing time for the dough and recipe to achieve consistent volume while preventing overproofing, contamination, and burns.

Main parts

- Insulated cabinet or proofing chamber
- Trays, racks, or trolley supports
- Heating element and temperature controller
- Humidity or water reservoir system, if fitted
- Circulation fan and ventilation openings
- Control panel, door seal, and power supply

Before you start

1. Confirm the dough type, batch size, and proofing requirements from the recipe or production procedure.
2. Inspect the chamber, racks, trays, door seal, controls, fan, and electrical cable for damage or contamination.
3. Clean and sanitise food-contact surfaces using approved food-safe methods.
4. Check the water reservoir or humidity system, if fitted, and ensure the drain is clear.
5. Verify that temperature and humidity controls operate correctly and that the chamber is free of cleaning chemicals.
6. Wash hands and use clean food-handling clothing and suitable PPE.

How to use

1. Switch on the proofer and set the temperature and humidity according to the recipe or approved process.
2. Allow the chamber to reach the required conditions before loading the dough, unless the process specifies otherwise.
3. Place covered or appropriately protected dough pieces on clean trays with enough space for expansion.
4. Load trays or racks evenly without blocking air circulation or overloading the chamber.
5. Close the door securely and start the proofing timer or follow the monitored production schedule.
6. Observe temperature, humidity, and dough development at the specified intervals.

7. Check dough size and readiness using the approved visual or process criteria rather than relying only on time.
8. Adjust the process only within the permitted recipe and equipment settings.
9. If abnormal temperature, excessive condensation, contamination, or equipment failure occurs, stop the process and notify the responsible operator.
10. Remove trays carefully using suitable heat protection if surfaces are warm.
11. Transfer proofed dough to the next production stage without unnecessary delay or contamination.
12. Switch off the unit when required, clean and dry the chamber, and record process deviations or maintenance needs.

⚠ Safety

- Only trained personnel should operate or clean the proofer.
- Do not touch heating elements, hot racks, or hot internal surfaces with bare hands.
- Keep water away from exposed electrical parts and disconnect power before maintenance.
- Use clean hands, utensils, and trays to prevent food contamination.
- Do not block ventilation openings or operate the unit with damaged electrical parts.
- Follow food-safety procedures for dough holding times and temperatures.

Care & storage

- Clean trays, racks, chamber walls, door seals, and water reservoirs regularly.
- Remove crumbs and moisture after shutdown to prevent mould and odours.
- Inspect door seals, fans, temperature sensors, and humidity controls for wear or faults.
- Descale or clean the water reservoir according to the manufacturer's instructions.
- Arrange servicing if temperature or humidity becomes unstable.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Loading dough before the chamber reaches the required conditions when preheating is specified.
- Setting temperature or humidity incorrectly for the recipe.
- Overloading trays or blocking air circulation.
- Leaving food residue or standing water inside the chamber.

Disclaimer: This SOP is prepared from general information available on the internet. For detailed instructions, refer to the manufacturer's original manual / file.

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